

ANALYSING MACAULAY

I stress on the teaching of vernacular in our English schools. Indeed I conceive that an order to give instruction in the English language is, by necessary implication, an order to give instruction, where that instruction is required, in the vernacular language. . . . Teaching vernaculars seems to me to be bona fide part of an English education. I would be glad to furnish these schools with good Hindee books.

– Thomas Babington Macaulay, 1836¹

Background to Macaulay's Minute

By 1835, every educational institution established by the colonial state taught Arabic and Sanskrit, and every Indian effort was geared towards acquiring modern education and the English language. The Education Department, dominated by the British Orientalist Arabic scholars, wanted to introduce medical education and modern scientific and technical knowledge through Arabic language. The Indians wanted to acquire the same through English and translate it into modern Indian vernaculars.² Therefore, there was a disparity between what the colonial state was willing to offer and what Indians actually wanted in the field of education. The Orientalists and other elite British officials continued to argue that the 'native prejudice' prevented the introduction of modern education and declared 'the natives would at best be smatterers of English . . . in the hope of a livelihood and not in any love of science for its own sake.'³ This was a clear misrepresentation of facts. Indians were demanding the introduction of modern education across India. These demands were not limited to urban centres; they came from rural hinterlands as well. Since the 1790s, Indians were removed from all positions of responsibility, and the only jobs available to Indians were those of pundits and kazis in the courts; sepoys, or soldiers in the army; police guards; and assistants in the Revenue Department; none of these jobs required knowledge of the English language.⁴ So the Indian aspiration for modern education was not linked to jobs in the administration. The curriculum of the

schools established by Indians also shows that they aspired to not only learn the English language but also the entire gamut of modern knowledge.

In spite of this evidence, H.T. Prinsep insisted time and again in his Minutes that 'English education was confined to tracing alphabets and the lisping of grammars by people who should be studying (oriental) philosophy.' This went against obvious evidence available in Calcutta itself. The students of the Vidyalaya studied Shakespeare, Milton, Dryden, and Pope's *Iliad* and *Odyssey*.⁵ By 1829, India had produced its first English poet – Kashi Prasad Ghosh (1809–1873). He published a collection of poems titled *The Shair and Other Poems*. Ghosh was not a Westernised Anglophile; rather, he exhibited 'patriotic fervour' and opposition to social reforms.⁶ English education had produced not just reformers like Rammohan Roy and Dwarkanath Tagore but also equally powerful anti-reformers like Kashi Prasad Ghosh and Radhakant Deb. In 1832, the Select Committee of the House of Commons accepted that, in spite of a great demand by the natives for the introduction of English education, 'the subject has not hitherto met with consideration and encouragement from the government.'⁷

During 1827–1834, five important developments took place which directly undermined the power of the Orientalists who had hitherto controlled Indian education through a combination of tampering with evidence and misrepresentation of facts. The great reform movement in England which preceded the renewal of the Charter of the East India Company led to a detailed and exhaustive review of the Indian education system by the British Parliament. The arrival of William Bentinck, Charles Trevelyan, and Macaulay in Calcutta made it more difficult for the Orientalists. Finally, it was the departure of H.H. Wilson, the master manipulator among the Orientalists, to England, which weakened their position.

William Bentinck

Bentinck, an outspoken critic of EIC, became the governor-general of India in 1827. He described the British rule in India as 'cold, selfish and unfeeling; the iron hand of power on the one side, monopoly on the other.'⁸ He sought to protect Indians from the oppressive acts of British officers, openly supported 'political liberty,' and spoke against 'selfish commercial prosperity.' Though he was the brother-in-law of the British prime minister, his appointment as the governor-general of India was vetoed in 1822 and accepted in 1827 only because five other shortlisted candidates refused the position.⁹

As soon as Bentinck arrived in India, he astounded every one by doing away with the pomp and pageantry introduced by Wellesley and travelled alone, even without an escort. He also allowed Indians to directly approach him and to drive up to the government house in their own carriage, which had been forbidden since Wellesley's time. Bentinck abolished corporal punishment for the native soldiers. He was also concerned with

the establishment of the principle of equality of law in India and wanted a single code of law for the whole population, 'black and white, native and European.' Bentinck attacked high salaries of senior civil servants in India. The British army officials subjected Bentinck to much personal abuse.¹⁰ He was unpopular among most of the British officials in India and had little support in England.

Bentinck increased the scope and responsibilities for Indians in government employment by proposing to appoint them to higher positions. This meant that Indians could compete with British officers on equal terms for positions in the EIC service.¹¹ He was ably supported by a group of Scottish MPs, such as Joseph Hume, Charles and Robert Grant, the sons of Charles Grant, and T.B. Macaulay. Charles Grant, who had grown up in India, argued that 'we should acknowledge the political existence of the natives, and it would be unjust . . . to forget the political existence of the natives.'¹² Grant also insisted that there should be 'nothing to prevent a native from becoming a member of the (governor-general's) Council.'¹³ Macaulay, in his speech, argued that the British should not be allowed to 'trample' the native population and 'the governor-general must therefore be enabled to restrict European privileges through legislation, overruling even the Supreme courts if necessary. He was also persistent upon the clause which removed 'barriers to Indians from holding high offices.'¹⁴ The idea that an Indian could hold high offices and become a member of the governor-general's Council, the highest legislative and executive body of British India, was in itself a revolutionary idea. The appointment of Indians to all positions of responsibility in the administration required a large body of Indians with fluency in English and an understanding of the workings of a modern administrative setup. This required a direct encouragement to modern education. Bentinck unequivocally opposed the Orientalists who believed that keeping Indians ignorant of modern education was in the best interest of the British in India:

My entire dissent from the opinions of those who think it better that the natives remain in ignorance. I cannot recognise the advantage of ignorance to the governors or the governed. If our rule is bad, as I believe it to be, let the natives have the means, through knowledge, to represent their grievances and to obtain redress. . . . I approve therefore of every plan by which the human mind can be instructed and of course, elevated. . . . General education is my panacea for the regeneration of India.¹⁵

In addition to his strong support for modern education, Bentinck supported Indian social reformers. He extended state support to Rammohan Roy's campaign against sati. The Orientalists, such as H.H. Wilson and H.T. Prinsep, openly supported *sati*.¹⁶ By abolishing sati, Bentinck antagonised the Orientalists.

Charles Trevelyan in Calcutta

Charles Trevelyan was born in 1807, the fourth son of nine children of George Trevelyan, a Cornish clergyman. 'The family expected Charles the most promising one to lift the family out of hardship.' He came to India in 1826 and was appointed as an assistant to the British resident at Delhi. Due to his youth, Edward Colebrooke, the British resident at Delhi, called him 'a boy just escaped from school.' However, Colebrooke's mistake in evaluating his young assistant cost him dearly. Trevelyan's 'sense of public duty was perhaps his single most defining characteristic.' He was a devout Christian but worked on Sundays also as 'he felt that duty commanded it. He also vehemently opposed the government support to Missionaries.'¹⁷

Trevelyan was removed from Delhi because of two important reasons. First, in 1828, when he was appointed to the committee of the Delhi College, he introduced English as a course of study and personally mentored the students entering the English class. He even made arrangements for one of the students of the first batch to visit England. As a 21-year-old idealist, Trevelyan envisioned the idea that rich-poor, upper caste-lower caste, Hindu, and Muslim boys studying in the same class would 'possibly become one people.'¹⁸ The Orientalists disliked it. Second, Trevelyan took on his corrupt but powerful boss, Edward Colebrooke, who was the son of the former chairman of the East India Company and the older brother of the Orientalist Henry Thomas Colebrooke. In spite of the hostility of Delhi's European residents, Trevelyan saw the prosecution through to its conclusion and got Colebrooke suspended from the service in 1829.¹⁹ After this, Trevelyan was called back to Calcutta. The Orientalists had not expected that his return would bring his battle into their own home – the GCPI.

In the GCPI, Trevelyan clashed with the Orientalists on two issues. As one proficient in Sanskrit, he did not oppose teaching Sanskrit or Sanskrit literature in colleges. He supported the proposal of the Asiatic Society for the publication of Sanskrit and Arabic works.²⁰ However, Trevelyan opposed the extreme Orientalists' idea of devoting higher education exclusively to Sanskrit and Arabic to the utter neglect of Indian vernaculars. He supported the teaching of vernaculars at Haileybury College in England, which trained civil servants sent to India, while the Orientalist Wilson was opposed to it. Trevelyan also opposed John Tytler, who wanted to translate Western scientific works only into Arabic and not into any Indian vernaculars, thus making Arabic the medium of instruction in the proposed Calcutta Medical College.²¹ He was also the first to raise the issue of the educational backwardness of Assam and the northeast areas of British India and fought with the Orientalists to establish the first set of schools in Assam during 1834–1835. When the Orientalists told him that the government did not have funds, he demanded a statement of actual expenditure for 100,000 rupees earmarked by the British Parliament and numerous endowments handed

over by the people of India into the hands of GCPI.²² The Orientalists hated Trevelyan for his proactive behaviour and projected him as an enemy of Sanskrit language.

Appointment of Macaulay as Law Member

Thomas Babington Macaulay's father, Zachary Macaulay, came from an impoverished background in Scotland. At the age of 16 he became a book keeper on a Jamaican plantation, where he witnessed extremely inhuman treatment of African slaves by the Europeans. At the age of 22 he returned to England and joined the anti-slavery group in Clapham and became closely involved with the settlement of freed slaves in Sierra Leone.²³

Thomas Babington Macaulay was born on 25 October 1800 and grew up with his eight siblings. Since Zachary was away most of the time in anti-slavery campaigns, Macaulay as the eldest son felt responsible for the care and well-being of his mother, five sisters, and three brothers – particularly, his two immediate sisters, who were in bad health. Zachary was very authoritarian; he refused to send Macaulay to a day school in London and packed him off to a private boarding-school at the age of 13. This forced separation from his siblings was traumatic. Added to this trauma were beatings and bullying from larger boys in the boarding-school.²⁴ This private boarding-school was conducted by the 'rigidly Evangelical Matthew Preston.' Macaulay rebelled against the 'evangelical' atmosphere and developed 'insensibility to the religious passion.' Within three months of staying at the school, Macaulay in a debate attacked Christian crusaders for killing unarmed Muslims. He triumphantly wrote to his father that 'it is a fact that the Crusaders put to death 70,000 Mahomedans in the streets of Jerusalem tho' they implored mercy on their knees.'²⁵ Throughout his life Macaulay abhorred religious passion and strongly advocated secular public space.²⁶ He consciously maintained a distance from his father.²⁷ Later, during his college days, he associated himself with secular and progressive groups. Zachary wrote to his wife, 'I am quite shocked and pained that a son of mine should have linked himself with such associates.'²⁸

At the personal level, the two childhood traumas of forcible separation from the family and bullying at school probably made him both extremely sensitive of familial ties and extremely hostile to his opponents.²⁹ Even as an adult he 'cried his eyes out' while reading books or when separated from his sisters, while he lashed out at his adversaries in no uncertain terms.³⁰ Throughout his busy public life, he eagerly awaited letters from his sisters and wrote to them regularly.³¹ He remained unmarried and devoted his personal life to his siblings. While in India, Macaulay vehemently opposed Trevelyan's proposal to set up residential schools for Indian children. He told him that he would approve of institutions to keep children safe when parents were at work during the day but not the institutions that separated

children from their parents. Macaulay argued that ‘the relation of parent and the child is the foundation of all society. . . . To substitute the school-master for the mother as the guardian of an infant is not in my opinion a wise course.’³² When Trevelyan argued that the ‘corrupting influence of the zanana’ on the children could be avoided by establishing residential schools, Macaulay wrote:

I would rather hear a boy of three years old lisp all the bad words in the language than he should have no feelings of family affection. The dissolution of the tie between parent and the child is a great moral evil. It is a misfortune to have a school master in place of a mother.³³

When Trevelyan persisted, Macaulay threatened to handover funds earmarked for education to ‘a riding school’ rather than establish residential schools which separated Indian children from their families.³⁴ Though Macaulay upheld family values, he did not hesitate to stand up for what he believed was right. He opposed his father’s religious ideas and on many issues refused to support his brother-in-law Trevelyan during his tenure in India.³⁵

In school, Macaulay learnt Greek and Latin and acquired proficiency in both languages. Though he enjoyed Latin literature, he refused to attribute any intrinsic merit to the ancient languages. Later, as a member of Parliament, he argued that it was better for a civil servant about to be sent to India ‘to learn a tribal language than dead languages like Greek and Latin.’³⁶ At the age of 18, he joined Cambridge and came under the influence of Thomas Paine’s *Age of Reason*. He shared the goals of secularism almost a generation before the word was coined. Macaulay argued that ‘morality should be based on the well-being of mankind in the present life, to the exclusion of all consideration drawn from belief in god.’ He also believed that ideally ‘education should concern the present or visible world as distinguished from the eternal or spiritual world.’³⁷ When Macaulay met James Mill and his young friends in the London Debating Society, he was ‘struck by Puritanism and a taste for abstract theorising’ and called the Utilitarians men ‘whose attainments just suffice to elevate them from insignificance of dunce to the dignity of bores.’³⁸ He considered James Mill his ‘old enemy’ even though Mill supported his appointment as a Law Member for India.³⁹ The Utilitarian journal *Westminster Review* attacked the *Edinburgh Review*; Macaulay chose the latter in which to write his articles. In contrast, Macaulay considered Rammohan Roy a ‘remarkable man’ and in 1831 waited at a gathering in London until midnight to meet him but went away in despair.⁴⁰

Macaulay had an inherent disdain for the rich and powerful. He stressed that ‘a historian should be wider in his sympathies and more curious

about life as lived by ordinary men and women.’ He argued that the major changes which had taken place in the history of mankind had been ‘noiseless revolutions.’

The circumstances which have most influence on the happiness of mankind, the changes of manners and morals, the transition of communities from poverty to wealth, from ignorance to knowledge, from ferocity to humanity are for the most part noiseless revolutions. Their progress is rarely indicated by what historians are pleased to call important events. They are not achieved by armies, or earned by senates. They are sanctioned by no treaties, and recorded in no archives. They are carried on in every school, in every church, behind ten thousand counters, at ten thousand firesides. The upper current of society presents no certain criterion by which we can judge of the direction in which the under current flows. We read of defeats and victories. But we know that nations may be miserable amidst victories and prosperous amidst defeats. We read of the fall of wise ministers and of the rise of profligate favourites. But we must remember how small a proportion the good and evil affected by a single statesman can bear to the good or evil of a great social system.⁴¹

Macaulay also argued that ‘the balance of moral and intellectual influence’ between the nations was ‘far more important than the balance of power.’⁴²

Macaulay became a member of Parliament at the age of 30. Immediately, he supported Robert Grant who tabled A Bill to remove the disabilities suffered by Jews in Britain. Macaulay’s maiden speech was directed at giving equality to British Jews, who had no civil rights until then to enter educational institutions, hold offices, or contest elections. He fought against ‘intolerant and absurd restriction on Jews to hold public offices’ and ‘suggested making Jews into Englishmen and members of the community’ by giving them equal educational and employment opportunities. The Bill was defeated. Macaulay did not rest. He passionately wrote about it and ardently spoke on the Bill when it was reintroduced in 1833. Macaulay ‘rested his contentions on equality of civic status, the natural rights of native-born Englishmen and the inherent commonsense of the case as well as the plain fairness and justice of it.’ When the opponents argued that ‘the religious differences made the Jews unfit to be a legislator in a Christian country,’ Macaulay countered them by stating that

the points of difference between Christianity and Judaism have very much to do with a man’s fitness to be a bishop or a rabbi, but they have no more to do with his fitness to be a magistrate, a legislator or a minister of finance than with his fitness to be a cobbler.⁴³

His contribution to obtain equality for Jews during 1830–1833 was unmatched by him or anyone else in its immediate impact. His hard-hitting argument enabled the Bill to be passed in the House of Commons, but it was defeated in the House of Lords.⁴⁴ During the course of the debate, opponents asked

if once you admit into the House of Commons people who deny the authority of the Gospels [will] you let in a Mussulman? Will you let in a Parsi? Will you let in a Hindoo, who worships a lump of stone with seven heads?⁴⁵

Macaulay stood up for equal treatment of all human beings irrespective of religious beliefs and differences. He told Parliament that

I am not a Roman Catholic; but if I were a judge at Malta, I should have no scruple about punishing a bigoted Protestant who should burn the Pope in effigy before the eyes of thousands of Roman Catholics. I am not a Mussulman; but if I were a judge in India, I should have no scruple about punishing a Christian who should pollute a mosque.⁴⁶

He also argued for ‘a great and extensive reform in the whole system of our civil and criminal jurisprudence.’⁴⁷

In 1832, the debate on the renewal of the EIC’s Charter began in the British parliament. Macaulay immediately took interest in it and began to familiarise himself with the happenings in India to prepare for the debate. He said of the British Empire in India, ‘the empire is itself the strangest of all political anomalies.’⁴⁸ He expressed regret that the British Parliament paid less attention to events in India than to minor incidents in England.⁴⁹ He took part in drafting the terms of the Charter Act of 1833. During the speech, he also urged for ‘judicial reforms in India to prevent the British officers from treating all the native population as pariahs.’⁵⁰ In order to maintain impartiality and safeguard the interests of Indians, he saw to it that the newly created position of Law Member in the governor-general’s Council was not an employee of the East India Company. He inserted the equality clause which gave equal access to employment to Indians. The clause provided that ‘no person, by reason of his birth, creed, or colour, should be disqualified from holding any office in the service of the East India Company.’ He considered this his proudest achievement.⁵¹

His work for the Charter Act of 1833 made Macaulay irreplaceable. Macaulay was appointed Law Member to draft the Indian Penal Code. The main reason for accepting the position was economic distress. His large family had survived on his fellowship amount during his Cambridge days and later on his salary as an MP. Due to his vociferous opposition to the rich and powerful, his ‘political future was bleak,’ and he feared that he would

not be re-elected.⁵² Macaulay hoped to stay for four years in India and save 50 per cent of his salary for his family, which at that time ‘felt so acutely the constant humiliation, and poverty.’⁵³

Once he accepted the position of the first Law Member in the governor-general’s Council, he told his sister that ‘it was his “peculiar” charge to act as the guardian of the people of India against the European settlers,’ and he ‘warned her against choosing an English maid who would oppress their Indian servants.’⁵⁴ Macaulay reached Madras on 10 June 1834 and drove to Nilgiri hills as governor-general Bentinck was recovering from ill health at Ooty. On his way, he noted the villages had ‘much on equality with the villages of Wales and Scotland.’ He noticed ‘the carving on timber over the doors of the houses’ and its taste and skill reminded him of ‘wood-work of some of our fine Gothic chapels and cathedrals.’ In Ooty, a hill station, ‘his bed was heaped with blankets,’ while all his servants who had accompanied him from Madras were coughing as they wore thin cloths suitable for hot and humid Madras. He immediately ‘bought them thick woollen cloths.’ After meeting Bentinck, he was asked to proceed to Calcutta and given a native Christian servant to accompany him. A day before he was to leave, the servant was accused of adultery and was to be arrested. Macaulay asked the local British officer to hold immediate trial. It was held throughout the night, conducted by an Indian Judge who declared him not guilty. Macaulay sat through the proceedings and ‘witnessed first hand the working of Indian judicial system.’ He was not convinced of the innocence of his servant and wrote that ‘it was a lesson how not to administer British justice in a remote Indian village.’ Next morning, Macaulay sent the servant in a palanquin to make arrangements before his own arrival. As the servant’s ‘palanquin moved out, Macaulay heard disturbance and looked out and saw his servant’s palanquin was mobbed by angry villagers. The servant had been pulled out, almost stripped naked, and was about to pull him to pieces.’ Macaulay rushed out of the house with a sword to defend his servant. He held the servant in his arms, where he fainted away. Macaulay commented that ‘like most of his countrymen, he is a chicken hearted fellow.’ The mob surrounded them with raised fists and refused to allow Macaulay to put his servant back into the palanquin. They were soon rescued by the guards of Bentinck’s house, which was close by.⁵⁵

How do we analyse this episode? Should we just take his comment that Indians are ‘chicken hearted,’ call him racist, and ignore the rest of his activities? Shouldn’t one also look at the fact that the second most powerful man in British India took up sword to protect his low-caste servant? History should record both.

The educational debate, 1834–1835

Macaulay reached Calcutta in September 1834 and settled down to write the Indian Penal Code. As a Law Member, he automatically became a member

of the GCPI; however, he showed no interest in the ongoing debates. He concentrated on reforming the Indian judicial system. Within six months of his arrival in Calcutta, Macaulay 'drafted legislation to subject Europeans to the civil jurisdiction and limit their direct access to the Supreme Court in Calcutta to criminal cases.' This was denounced by the Europeans as the 'black act,' and they pillared Macaulay with 'their invectives.' They asked the EIC authorities to call him back to Britain. Until Macaulay introduced this law, if the British had refused to return the money owed to Indians or beat them up, the injured party could appeal only to the Supreme Court in Calcutta. The distance and expenses were prohibitive. Many dishonest British officers misused this rule to silence Indians by threatening to sue them in the Supreme Court at Calcutta. Macaulay argued that 'from what I have myself seen the dread with which natives regard the Supreme Court,' the British should be brought to the same local jurisdiction as that of the natives.⁵⁶ The British officers and civilians in India feared Macaulay's insistence of legal equality would end their racial superiority. They continuously attached him through petitions and newspaper writings throughout his stay in India. So like Bentinck, Macaulay had very little support among the British both within India and in England. When Macaulay entered the education debate, Dwarkanath Tagore and the entire rank and file of reformers and the Orthodox Hindus and Muslims joined him to fight the Orientalists.⁵⁷

Throughout 1834, the GCPI witnessed hostility between H.T. Prinsep and Trevelyan, who were at the extreme ends of the arguments. The Orientalists, such as J.C.C. Sutherland, W.H. Macnaughten, and James Prinsep, were very strong supporters of Prinsep. Support for Trevelyan came from Bushby, while Bird, Saunders, J.R. Colvin, and Henry Shakespeare preferred the limited introduction of modern education.⁵⁸ Prinsep took uncompromising opposition to the introduction of Indian vernaculars, English, and modern sciences in any educational institution. Prinsep opposed the teaching of Hindi at Agra College and insisted that Arabic and Sanskrit alone constituted 'the learning and literature of the country.'⁵⁹ He also argued that the original endowment of Gangadhar Pandit was not for teaching Hindi, English, and modern sciences.⁶⁰ Actually, the original endowment was for teaching Sanskrit alone and not Arabic, which Prinsep ignored conveniently. Prinsep opposed teaching English to Muslim students at Madrasa as he considered them low class.⁶¹ Shakespeare opposed Prinsep and supported 'the right of Muslim population to the benefit of the college and to learn English.'⁶² Prinsep made the stopping of teaching of English at Calcutta Madrasa the condition for allowing the functioning of the GCPI.⁶³ The GCPI came to a standstill. Colvin reported in his Minute that in enforcing a blanket ban on the introduction of English education, Prinsep stood alone.⁶⁴

Unable to bear the pressure, Henry Shakespeare resigned as the president of the GCPI in December 1834. In his letter to the government he stated that he was resigning

in the hope that the government would induce Mr Macaulay to lend the aid of his talent to the cause of education by fitting the chair. . . . Macaulay, whose high literary attainments and his zeal for the dissemination of sciences are well known.⁶⁵

Prinsep conveyed it to Macaulay.⁶⁶ Macaulay became the president of the GCPI on 8 December 1834. Still, he did not enter the debate. At that time, his sister Hannah was in the process of getting married to Charles Trevelyan; the ceremony took place 23 December. The next day, Macaulay received the news that his favourite sister, Margaret, had died in England. Bentinck and his wife rushed to comfort him and found him so distraught that they begged Hannah and Trevelyan to cut short their honeymoon and return immediately.⁶⁷ Macaulay was so depressed that he took no notice of the developments within the GCPI.

In the meantime, a resolution drafted by George Alexander Bushby argued that it was ‘injustice to the people of India’ to withhold teaching English as ‘respectable knowledge of English is essential for public appointments.’ He also urged the governor-general to break his silence on this issue. Trevelyan ‘entirely conceded in the justice of the sentiments expressed by Bushby.’⁶⁸ On the same day, Sutherland wrote to James Prinsep that the natives of Kota had established an English school and attributed it to ‘public employment.’ He opposed such measures by arguing that education was meant ‘for those who profess leisure.’ In the same letter he admitted that the English publications sold better than the Arabic translations of modern sciences.⁶⁹ The following day, Sutherland revived Minto and Colebrooke’s 1812 proposal of establishing Sanskrit College at Nadia and argued that ‘the revival and improvement of the literature of the country’ was essential ‘to win the confidence of the educated and influential classes of the people.’⁷⁰

On 26 January 1835, John Tytler, defending the Orientalist position, directly wrote to Macaulay. Tytler was an Arabic scholar like Prinsep, and they both promoted the introduction of modern sciences only through Arabic. Earlier in 1829, the GCPI decided that the ‘vernacular languages are not eligible to teach sciences . . . and sciences should be taught only in Sanskrit and Arabic.’ It ordered the translation of important books into Arabic and Sanskrit.⁷¹ Tytler opposed the use of Sanskrit to teach sciences and during 1829–1833 vigorously campaigned to make Arabic the sole language through which to teach sciences, including medicine.⁷² In 1833, Tytler insisted on teaching medical sciences through Arabic in all medical colleges across India. Trevelyan opposed it and had called it ‘absurd’ as ‘Arabic is nobody’s

language. . . . If English is adopted as the medium of instruction – native doctors can become medium of communication between the European medical sciences and the natives.’ Trevelyan also stated that ‘there are not more than 300 persons proficient in Arabic language and Tytler, an assistant surgeon is the only person proficient to teach medical sciences in Arabic.’⁷³

Now Tytler directly approached Macaulay. He defended his position of giving medical education to Indians through Arabic on the basis of the following points. First, the natives could acquire only ‘a mere smattering of English’ – not sufficient English to learn medical sciences; second, the vernaculars or as Tytler called ‘derivative language, cannot be understood clearly or used accurately without some knowledge of the language from which it has its origin. So ‘the highly cultivated parent language (like Arabic) should be used for scientific purposes.’ Finally, Tytler insisted that though ‘all Eastern Science contained falsehood,’ yet they should be taught.⁷⁴ This shows that Tytler as an Orientalist had a very low opinion of Ayurveda. Macaulay in his reply countered Tytler:

Our difference of opinion is quite fundamental. I do not conceive that discussion is likely to bring us nearer to each other. I deny every one of your premises without exception. . . . I deny that no derivative language can be well understood without a knowledge of the original language; the best and most idiomatic English has been written by men who knew neither Anglo-Saxon nor Norman French. . . . We must provide the people with something to say, before we trouble ourselves about the style which they say it in. Does it matter in what grammar a man talks nonsense?⁷⁵

Macaulay argued that, ‘if the eastern sciences contained falsehood in the light of Copernican astronomy,’ why should they be taught?

I am not convinced of this. I know that your Sanskrit and Arabic books do not sell. I know that the English books of the School Book Society do sell. I know that you cannot find a single person at your Colleges who will learn Sanskrit and Arabic without being paid for it. I know that students who learn English are willing to pay. I believe therefore that the native population if left to itself would prefer our mode of education to yours. At all events the *onus probandi* (burden of proof) lies upon you.⁷⁶

Macaulay had at last entered the debate.

Macaulay’s Minute, 1835

Macaulay in his Minute of 2 February 1835 attempted to reply to the five important arguments put forth by the Orientalists. He began his defence of

introducing English and modern science by drawing extensively from the arguments put forth by Rammohan Roy's letter of 1823. First, he argued that the clause in the Charter Act of 1813 regarding 'the improvement of literature and the encouragement of the learned natives of India and for the introduction and promotion of a knowledge of the sciences' among Indians was not limited to 'the sacred books of the Hindus' but extended to 'the poetry of Milton, the metaphysics of Locke, and the physics of Newton.' Second, Macaulay accepted the evaluation of Oriental literature by Orientalists. He admitted that

I have no knowledge of either Sanskrit or Arabic . . . I am quite ready to take the oriental learning at the valuation of the Orientalists themselves. *I have never found one among them who could deny that a single shelf of a good European library was worth the whole native literature of India and Arabia.* The intrinsic superiority of the Western literature is indeed fully admitted by those members of the committee who support the oriental plan of education.⁷⁷

This was not Macaulay's opinion. He was actually quoting the opinions of the Orientalists. Macaulay, who had come to India only five months before writing this Minute, took the evaluation of Indian literature from the Orientalists who knew the languages well and had stayed over 20 to 30 years in India. Throughout this Minute, Macaulay summed up the Orientalist arguments to pertinently question the Orientalists' opposition to modern education. In fact, Macaulay placed the Arabic and Sanskrit poetry very high in comparison with European poetry, while for H. T. Prinsep 'the quality of literature of England was far superior to that of Arabic and Sanskrit.'⁷⁸ This clearly shows that the Orientalists did not admire Arabic and Sanskrit literature but were using it only to prevent the spread of modern education in India. Macaulay further argued that 'the sciences that are essential for human progress have developed in Europe' mainly because 'our ancestors did not behave like the GCPI, confining their attention to the old dialects of our own island, printing nothing and taught nothing at the universities but chronicles in Anglo-Saxon and romances in Norman French.' He quoted the example of Russia's attempt to modernise itself through Western European languages.⁷⁹ Prinsep opposed it by stating that 'Bacon, Locke and Newton could be taught to the Maulvis and Pundits through Arabic and Sanskrit.' Prinsep also refuted Macaulay's choice of teaching vernaculars along with English by stating that 'vernacular dialects are not fit to be made the vehicle of instruction in sciences and literature.'⁸⁰ By opposing Orientalist policy of limiting education to Brahmins, Macaulay was paving the way for all Indians irrespective of castes to have direct access to modern education.

The third argument of the Orientalists was that 'the native cooperation could be secured only by encouraging the study of Arabic and Sanskrit.'

Macaulay questioned this: 'Why then is it necessary to pay people to learn Sanscrit and Arabic? While those who learn English are willing to pay us.'⁸¹ Prinsep countered Macaulay by arguing that 'the study of English is nauseated because it requires to be paid for and is surely no proof of the violent desire for instruction in English which is inferred from it.' Prinsep insisted that, 'if any step be taken hastily and without a thorough comprehension of the subject,' it would turn out to be 'hateful and injurious to the mass of people.' Macaulay quoted the Sanskrit scholar Radhakant Deb's statement that 'nobody in India studies Sanskrit profoundly without being paid to do so.'⁸² Macaulay stated that, if the government stopped paying to the students studying Arabic and Sanskrit, no one would enter these institutions. Lal Behari Day, who was a witness to these debates during 1835, also stated that 'while Arabic and Sanskrit students had to be bribed to learn these languages, the doors of English schools were crowded with boys begging for admission.'⁸³ This was due to two reasons: first, not all Muslims and Brahmins wanted to be priests and religious scholars; second, both the Hindus and Muslims had intellectual curiosity to learn new languages and new knowledge. So Macaulay concluded that the native society, left to itself, would prefer English and modern sciences. He also pointed out that

twenty-three thousand volumes of Arabic and Sanskrit books which were printed at a cost of 60,000 lay unsold . . . the School Book Society is selling seven or eight thousand English volumes every year, and not only pays the expenses of printing but realise a profit of twenty per cent, on its outlay.⁸⁴

If Hindus and Muslims had interest only in Arabic and Sanskrit, they would have bought these books and not English books. He also pointed out that the Orientalist had evaluated Arabic and Sanskrit literature as containing 'false history, false astronomy and false medicine' and asked why this should be encouraged if it was so.⁸⁵ Fourth, Macaulay refuted 'the perpetual argument by Orientalists' that no native of India could 'possibly attain more than a mere smattering of English.' So it was a waste of state resources to educate Indians in English. Macaulay asserted that

there are in this very town, natives who are quite competent to discuss political or scientific questions with fluency and precision in the English language. I have heard the very question on which I am now writing discussed by native gentlemen with a liberality and an intelligence which would do credit to any member of the Committee of Public Instruction. Indeed it is unusual to find, even in the literary circles of the continent, any foreigner who can express himself in English with so much facility and correctness as we find in many Hindoos.⁸⁶

The aggressive stand taken by Macaulay was in reply to the aggressive stand taken by Prinsep during 1834–1835. Finally, Macaulay agreed with the Orientalists that

it is impossible for us, with our limited means to attempt to educate the body of the people. We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern – a class of persons Indian in blood and colour, but English in tastes, in opinions, in morals and in intellect. To that class we may leave it to refine the vernacular dialects of the country, to enrich those dialects with terms of science borrowed from the Western nomenclature and to render them by degrees fit vehicles for conveying knowledge to the great mass of the population.⁸⁷

Macaulay's argument of making Indians into English in taste, opinions, morals, and intellect was not a new idea, nor it was directed only against Indians. He had used similar arguments to make British Jews into Englishmen during the Jewish emancipation debate. When Macaulay suggested the creation of a body of natives with modern education who would act as interpreters, it was not a new idea. Macaulay regularly visited Vidyalaya and had witnessed how its students after completing their studies were returning to their villages and small towns to establish schools and how English-educated Bengalis were translating modern knowledge and thought into Bengali. At that time in Bengal, the entire burden of modern education was on the shoulders of Indians, while the colonial state funded the Madrasa and Sanskrit Colleges. Petitions by hundreds of private schools across Bengal asking for governmental assistance either to repair the buildings or procure textbooks, globes, maps, or other teaching materials can be found in GCPI files.⁸⁸ Many of them mention where the petitioner or the headmaster had studied, in most cases in the Vidyalaya or Hooghly College. In 1855, Bengal had 151 secondary schools and colleges with 13,163 children, and all of them were private schools.⁸⁹ As late as 1870, people remembered how 'the alumni of the Hindu College established schools across the Presidency' and how the Hindu College students had the zeal to disseminate the knowledge they acquired.⁹⁰

Macaulay recognised that 'Benares is the great seat of Brahminical learning; Delhi of Arabic learning' and supported them, but he recommended the closing down of the Madrasa and the Sanskrit College at Calcutta and the stopping of printing of Arabic and Sanskrit books. Trevelyan and Macaulay opposed exclusive Sanskrit Colleges which were open to only Brahmins, but not teaching Sanskrit in schools and colleges along with modern sciences which were open to all. Rammohan Roy's Vidyalaya and Macaulay's schools at Azamgarh and Farrukabad were the first institutions to enable

non-Brahmins to learn Sanskrit. It was the Orientalists like Wilson and Prinsep who projected Trevelyan and Macaulay as anti-Sanskrit.

Macaulay recommended giving better financial assistance to the Vidyalaya and the establishment of modern schools in all principal towns and cities.⁹¹ Bentinck gave 'entire concurrence to the sentiments expressed in this Minute,' and the funds earmarked for education 'would be best employed on English education alone.' However, he did not abolish the existing Arabic and Sanskrit colleges; rather, he opposed the scheme of providing scholarship in them. He ordered that they be 'henceforth employed in imparting to the native population knowledge of science through the medium of the English language.'⁹²

Even after the Bentinck Resolution the Orientalists continued to oppose Macaulay. Supporting Prinsep, Sutherland argued that 'any further encouragement to English would give appearance of either coercion or of a political or religious design on the part of the government.' He also stated that 400 students in two Sanskrit Colleges for a population of 54 million in Bengal Presidency was sufficient and there was no need for further expansion.⁹³ He also argued that teaching English in Madrasa was 'systematically directed towards the destruction of the literature and religious system of Islam.'⁹⁴ Macnaughton, supporting Prinsep, argued that 'English taught in Madrasa should be elementary, as it is chimerical to expect that English will ever become the language of India.' He insisted that 'the natives are proverbially tenacious of the usage of their forefathers,' and the desire to learn English was on account of 'love of lucre.' He predicted that, when people realise that 'no worldly benefit could be obtained from learning English, a violent reaction will take place and it will be as a general body abandoned.'⁹⁵ His younger brother, James Prinsep, drew the attention of the GCPI to 'the government policy of teaching exclusively influential class of Brahmins since the time of Lord Minto.'⁹⁶ He, H.T. Prinsep, and Macnaughton resigned from the GCPI.⁹⁷ Macaulay remained 'unshaken' but admitted that he had used harsh language in his Education Minute. Soon after passing Macaulay's Minute, Bentinck left India. These are Bentinck's last statements about India just before he retired from his post:

Examine the whole scheme of this Indian system, and you will find the same result; poverty, inferiority, degradation in every shape. For all these evils, knowledge! knowledge! knowledge! is the universal cure.⁹⁸

The Court of Directors opposed Macaulay's Minute and placed 'a strict prohibition of any further changes of policy without consulting them.' John Stuart Mill opposed Bentinck's resolution and supported teaching Arabic and Sanskrit.⁹⁹ After the departure of Bentinck, Macaulay received support from Charles Metcalf, who was the acting governor-general. Macaulay

supported Metcalf in defending the freedom of the press and abolishing the Censorship Act. Macaulay supported the submission of the draft proposal to the people of Calcutta and invited their comments and suggestions.¹⁰⁰ This act was earlier imposed by governor-general Wellesley in 1799. Metcalf repealed the Censorship Act and freed the Indian press.¹⁰¹ For doing this Metcalf paid a very heavy price. He was not made the governor-general. The Court of Directors appointed Auckland, a very diplomatic but astute defender of elite privileges, as the governor-general to end the effects of Macaulay's Minutes.

Further conflict between Macaulay and the Orientalists, 1835–1838

The conflict between Macaulay and the Orientalists did not end with the endorsing of the Minute by Bentinck; it continued throughout his stay. Ignoring opposition from the Orientalists, Macaulay added two Indian members, Sanskrit scholar Radhakant Deb and Russomoy Dutt, to the GCPI. They were members with full powers and could vote on resolutions. Macaulay expressed concern that there was no Muslim representation in the GCPI. He hoped that Muslims, too, would take up the cause of education.¹⁰² Though lacking any support from governor-general Auckland, Macaulay continued to challenge the Orientalists within the GCPI. The information regarding this is contained in various Educational Minutes of Macaulay. Henry Woodrow, the Educational Inspector in Bengal, first presented these Minutes before a combined audience of liberal British and Indians of the Bethune Society in 1851 and published them in 1862. Though he has thanked W. Gordon Young and W.S. Atkinson, Directors of Public Instruction, it is possible that they granted permission before knowing the content of these Minutes. Woodrow was asked to remove certain Minutes in the last stages of book production – pages 28 and 42 contained only the following text: 'it has been considered desirable to omit the minute which originally occupied this space.'¹⁰³ Since the Minute of 2 February 1835 is printed in its entirety, these omitted Minutes may not have been derogatory to Indians but might have had information that would damage the reputation of the powerful British officers.

From these Minutes we know that Macaulay supported vernacular teaching in English schools and encouraged the employment of Indians in higher positions. Almost all these decisions were taken unilaterally with utter disregard for the opinions of the Orientalist members of the GCPI. These decisions, according to Macaulay, were essential as 'we are attempting to introduce a great nation to knowledge of the richest and noblest literature in the world.'¹⁰⁴ The decisions taken by Macaulay can be divided into the following categories.

Rural education

Macaulay was the first to talk of the educational backwardness of the rural hinterlands. Until then, the Orientalists had concentrated on establishing Arabic and Sanskrit colleges in urban centres, such as Calcutta, Banaras, Agra, and Delhi. Macaulay was the first to draw attention to the educational backwardness of Bihar and put up a proposal to establish a school in Patna.¹⁰⁵ Within five months he established an Anglo-vernacular school in Patna.¹⁰⁶ The first batch of students comprised 11 Brahmin, one Rajput, ten Khatri, 38 Kayasth, ten Bania, two Goala, two Kurmi, five native Christian, and 33 Muslims.¹⁰⁷ During the next three years, he established Anglo-vernacular schools in Ajmer, Azamgarh, Bareilly, Farukabad, Ghazipur, Gorakhpur, Jaunpur, and Jabalpur and raised the standard of existing local schools at Bhagalpur, Meerut, and Sagar.¹⁰⁸ He unsuccessfully tried to establish schools in Dacca, Bhundelkhand, Chittagong, and Comillah.¹⁰⁹ He argued that 'our schools are nurseries of school-masters for the future generation.' After the establishment of these schools, he suggested to the GCPI that a scheme for improving village schools was essential.¹¹⁰ He took keen interest in the appointment of teachers, purchases of books for the libraries, and evaluations of the essays written by students. When the number of students in Allahabad School doubled in seven months, he granted an additional sum of 30 rupees a month.¹¹¹

Secularisation of schools

Macaulay opposed teaching religion in schools and called Christian missions 'proselytising establishments,' and refused government support. He insisted that 'we ought to observe strict religious neutrality.'¹¹² He even opposed clergyman becoming members of the local committees of schools.¹¹³ He argued that both Hindus and Muslims should receive equal encouragement to take up modern education; otherwise, it would lead to 'either class to monopolise the benefits of public instruction.' When the Orientalists insisted on separate schools for Hindus and Muslims, he emphatically stated that 'I do not at all like the plan of separating the Hindus from Muslims.'¹¹⁴ After facing opposition from Macaulay, the GCPI agreed to admit the Hindus and Muslims into the same schools but came up with a proposal to give 'leave for Hindu boys on Hindu holidays and Muslim boys for Muslim holidays.' Macaulay called it 'ridiculous' and questioned how a teacher could teach only half a class if the other half is on holiday. He decided to give 'leave for both on both holidays.'¹¹⁵ He also insisted that 'we mean to give education gratis however if there is a need to levy fees, European and native children should study in the same schools and pay same fee.'¹¹⁶

Student-friendly decisions

Macaulay took several decisions that affected the lives of students too. Though the candidates for the post of teachers were very scarce, he dismissed a British schoolmaster for beating a native boy.¹¹⁷ He opposed a master teaching a class of 124 and insisted that a master should not have more than 30 boys. He regretted that 'we have not funds which will enable us to supply every thirty boys with a master.'¹¹⁸ He insisted that the school libraries 'should purchase books that are enjoyed by students and not expensive journals which only principal and professors will use them. We must never forget that we are forming libraries not for the English professors, but for the native students.'¹¹⁹ Macaulay emphasised purchasing books which would 'delight children.' He rejected the list of books selected by the Orientalists for the school libraries, stating, 'I do not like the list of books. Grammars of Rhetoric or Grammars of Logic are among the most useless furniture of a shelf. Give a boy Robinson Crusoe. That is worth all the grammars of rhetoric and logic in the world.' He also insisted on introducing simpler versions of the history books which contained more knowledge than the famous ones.¹²⁰ When the Orientalist members refused to heed his suggestion, he further argued that

we should clearly take into consideration the question, what books are most likely to be attractive to young native students of English? From little fairy tales they may be led on to Robinson Crusoe and Gulliver's Travels, and thence to Shakespeare and Milton.¹²¹

When the GCPI wanted to purchase books for prizes in schools and colleges, Macaulay opposed their selection.

It is absolutely unintelligible to me why Pope's works and my old friend Moor's Lalla Rookh should be selected from the whole mass of English poetry to be prize books. – Bacon's Essays, Hume's England, Gibbon's Rome, Arabian Nights . . . and many other delightful works which interest even the very young, and which do not lose their interest to the end of our lives. . . . A prize book ought to be a book which a boy receives with pleasure and turns over and over not as a task but spontaneously. I have not forgotten my own schoolboy feeling on this subject. My pleasure at obtaining a prize was greatly enhanced by the knowledge that my little library would receive a very agreeable addition.¹²²

Access to schools

When the Orientalist members of the GCPI could no longer prevent the establishment of Anglo-Vernacular schools by Macaulay, they tried to limit

their access to an extremely small group of rich upper-caste boys under the age of 10. Macaulay fought at every stage to ensure access was given to all. The Orientalists opposed the admission of 15–16-year-old boys into the Anglo-vernacular schools. Macaulay countered their opposition:

I cannot conceive why he should not be permitted to do so. . . . I do not very clearly see the reason for establishing a limit as to age. . . . I should be sorry to deny to any native of any age the facilities which our schools might afford to him for studying the English language.¹²³

Pereira, headmaster of the Furruckabad School, wanted to exclude poor boys from joining the school. Macaulay opposed Pereira and insisted that ‘our schools should be open to all.’¹²⁴ The local committee at Bhagalpore, consisting of British officials, decided to limit ‘boys of low parentage.’ Macaulay hit back: ‘I do not understand why the number of pupils of low caste parentage should be limited. . . . No such distinction ought to be tolerated in any school supported by us.’¹²⁵ The Orientalists continued to enforce class restrictions on the students. They proposed to divide ‘the Banaras college classes into rich and poor.’ Once again Macaulay opposed them.¹²⁶ Macaulay time and again challenged the notions of hierarchy upheld by the Orientalists and insisted that all children rich and poor, upper and lower caste should be treated equally within the classroom. He opposed the decision of the Delhi College to provide ‘chairs for boys of rank.’¹²⁷

The all-European Agra School Committee seated the lone native Christian boy separately in the classroom. Macaulay opposed it by stating that ‘the general rule ought to be that all classes should be treated alike and should intermingle freely.’¹²⁸ This lone native Christian boy was Balmokund, who along with Ram Dayal – a Sonar boy – and two Eurasian boys, Nicholas Patrick and Nicholas Pears, were in the top four positions in the class.¹²⁹ Still the Agra College Committee recommended 14 Brahmin students for various positions in the administration.¹³⁰ In 1837, Balmokund won the best prize for his essay. Again the Agra College Committee refused to give the prize because of his low birth and awarded it to the second-prize winner. Macaulay opposed it and called Balmokund’s essay better than the other two essays.¹³¹ Balmokund’s essay ‘On the Advantages of Education’ clearly demonstrated both hope and persecution. Balmokund wrote that ‘Diocletian was the son of a slave and yet assumed the sceptre of the whole Roman world by the help of a civil and military education; he was very prudent prince and his reign was illustrious in every respect.’ However, he was also critical of Diocletian’s persecution of Christians. For Balmokund, ‘all persecution is tyranny and most of all for liberty of thought.’¹³² Commenting on the essay, Macaulay called the behaviour of the Agra College Committee ‘too much in the style of Diocletian who is reprehended very

justly, by Balmokund.’ Macaulay not only opposed caste discrimination but also managed to get Balmokund a job as a librarian. Barkley Duncan, the secretary to the College Committee, opposed it by arguing that the aim should be ‘to extend the popularity of the institution among the better class of natives.’ However, the headmaster Wollarstone and Duncan were forced to obey Macaulay.¹³³ The Orientalist’s desire to promote only Brahmins and the landed gentry often came in conflict with Macaulay’s desire to uphold the common man.

Encouragement to vernacular teaching

Within five days of his famous Minute on education, Macaulay accepted William Adam’s proposal to study the indigenous schools of Bengal and Bihar in order to formulate a policy on vernacular schools.¹³⁴ The Orientalists opposed both Adam’s proposal and Macaulay’s encouragement to the study of vernacular in the newly established Anglo-vernacular schools. Macaulay, on his part, explained

I stress on the teaching of vernacular in our English schools . . . in fact their knowing how to read and write their mother tongue will, very greatly facilitate their English studies. Indeed I conceive that an order to give instruction in the English language is, by necessary implication, an order to give instruction, where that instruction is required, in the vernacular language. For what is meant by teaching a boy a foreign language? Surely this, the teaching him what words in the foreign language correspond to certain words in his own vernacular language, the enabling him to translate from the foreign language into his own vernacular language and vice versa. We learn one language – our mother tongue – by noticing the correspondence between words and things. But all the languages which we afterwards study, we learn by noticing the correspondence between the words in those languages and the words in our own mother tongue. Teaching the boys at Ajmer therefore to read and write Hindie language seems to me to be bona fide a part of an English education.¹³⁵

He even promised ‘I would willingly grant all the rent that is saved at the Allahabad school to the Hindi department.’¹³⁶ Prinsep opposed Macaulay’s ideas on vernacular education and argued that the Indian vernaculars were not fit to be taught in schools.¹³⁷ Macaulay ridiculed ‘the GCPI members for not knowing the vernaculars’ and ‘hoped that in twenty years time thousands of natives would translate European knowledge into vernacular.’¹³⁸ Macaulay opposed the divide between the educated English and the rest. He argued that ‘we mean these youths to be conductors of knowledge to the

people, and it is of no use to fill the conductors with knowledge at one end, if you separate them from the people at the other end.’ So the students in English schools should ‘know their vernacular well.’¹³⁹

Opposition to ostentation

The Orientalists, on the one hand, argued that the government lacked funds to appoint more schoolmasters or purchase books while continuing to provide funds to Banaras, Agra, and Delhi Colleges for improving ‘the taste.’ Macaulay opposed this by arguing that ‘plain school-rooms and good schoolmasters, an unadorned compound and a well-furnished library, are what in the present state of our funds, I should most wish to see.’¹⁴⁰ Macaulay also resisted ‘procuring things needed for the schools from England when similar things could be purchased in India at a much lesser price.’¹⁴¹ Macaulay was against giving medals to students for their performances. He argued that, ‘if you give the student the medal he has nothing but the honour. If you give him a certificate and the price of the medal, he has the honour and the hundred rupees into the bargain.’¹⁴²

Support to teachers

Macaulay supervised the appointment of teachers and argued that ‘good salary for teachers is essential—I would give 120 rupees a month. It is desirable not merely to keep good masters, but to prevent them from being always on the look-out for better situations.’ He was distressed by lack of suitable candidates.¹⁴³ Macaulay always looked into the day-to-day problems of schools and teachers, which was so crucial for the survival of early schools. In spite of the difficulty in finding schoolmasters, he was very strict with their conduct. He dismissed a schoolmaster for proselytising activities.¹⁴⁴ In 1837, the English master of the Bhagalpur School resigned as he could not get a suitable building for the proposed school and a house for his stay on rent. Macaulay immediately ordered the building of a schoolhouse with rooms for the master. He earmarked 50,000 rupees for similar cases that may arise in future.¹⁴⁵ In the same Minute he opposed the Orientalist scheme of appointing the brightest students of the schools as assistants under ‘pupilteachership’ to save money:

It will either stop the progress of the best students or provide lower classes bad masters . . . if the best are selected, their education is at an end. Just imagine what would be the effect in England of selecting all the best scholars of a public school, at the time when they would be leaving school for the university making them ushers, and condemning them to pass their time in teaching ‘*musa musae*’ and ‘*amo, amas, amat*’ to the boys of the lowest form. No system could

be devised more certain to stunt the minds of boys at the very time of life at which their minds might be expected to develop themselves most rapidly. Appoint additional teachers than to divert the attention of the most intelligent young men in the college from their own studies.¹⁴⁶

Macaulay left India in 1838 after completing the Indian Penal Code. The code was not adopted until 1860. The Indian Penal Code brought Hindus, Muslims, and Europeans under a single law. Macaulay's desire to establish an Anglo-vernacular school at Dacca was fulfilled when an Englishman by the name Robert Milford bequeathed a legacy to the people of Dacca. A public meeting was held on 11 June 1838. The meeting was led by Ramlochan Gose, Khaji Aleemollah, Jebun Kepen Roy, Robert Dowett, Mirza Golam Peer, and Mohamad Akmul Cawn. They drafted 'a petition in Bengali and English signed by 1400 people . . . proposed to pay chowkidari tax of the place to maintain the school.' They wanted the petition to be sent to the Court of Directors in London.¹⁴⁷ Earlier, Macaulay had fought unsuccessfully for the establishment of this school. It was unlikely that H.T. Prinsep forwarded it, as it is not available in the Board Collections.

What happened at the ground level also took place at the higher level. A British India Society was established in 1839 by Henry Peter Brougham, a liberal British MP. A public meeting was held in the same year in London which was attended by Nawaub Eckbaloodowlah, Prince of Awadh; Prince Jamal-ood-Deen, son of Tippoo Sultan; Meer Afzul Ali and Meer Kurreem Ali, agents of the Rajah of Sattara; Ichangheer Nowrojee, Hirjeebhoy Merwanjee, and Dorabjee Muncherjee of Bombay; and several British officers who had earlier served in India. They urged for government support to modern education.¹⁴⁸

An estimate of Macaulay

Macaulay has been extensively criticised for his harsh language and cultural disdain shown to Indians. There are two important aspects that need to be examined. First, was Macaulay particularly contemptuous towards Indians and Indian culture and not towards anything European? Second, how much of Indian history was known in 1835? To address the first issue, Macaulay's Education Minute was no different from any of his other writings – his historical essays, articles in journals, book reviews, and speeches in the Parliament. William Thomas has aptly called Macaulay's writings 'literary commando raids.'¹⁴⁹ His writing always contained 'biting and caustic criticism.' He spared no one. Macaulay's most 'contemptuous and vituperative reviews' were reserved for John Wilson Croker, a man of influence and a relative of Edmund Burke.¹⁵⁰ Most of the writings on Macaulay ignore these writings and other Education Minutes and emphasise his Minute of 2 February 1835.

Second, in 1835 very little of India's past was known. Most of the inscriptions, including Asokan inscriptions, had not been deciphered. Vedas and Upanishads had not been translated. Hence, the history of the ancient India was virtually unknown. Only the Dharmasastras, which uphold caste hierarchy and infant marriage, had been translated and used extensively by the colonial state as legal texts to dispense justice, and the Orientalists had passed off the Puranas as the authentic history of the Hindus. Macaulay openly stated that he took the Orientalist's evaluation of Indian literature as he did not know any Indian language. So Macaulay's disdain was not towards the Vedic and Upanishadic tradition or the mighty empires or the cultural and literary achievements of ancient India; rather, it was towards what the Orientalists had projected as Indian culture.

Historian Robert Frykenberg has dismissed the criticism of Macaulay's Minute. According to him,

every schoolboy and schoolgirl in India, figuratively speaking, is taught the myth of Macaulay's Minute. . . . According to this myth, attitudes of lofty condescension towards India's peoples and their inferior cultures, combined with practical needs for a cheap labour force to supply the manpower requirements of an enormous bureaucratic machine, prompted alien rulers to impose English language educational system upon the subcontinent and, thereby, to neglect and stifle the natural growth of indigenous educational institutions. Moreover, in its more extreme forms, this myth assumes that these rulers were also either racially arrogant or willfully ignorant, or both. Finally, this myth assumes that the disastrous consequences of this 'colonialist' fiat were a major factor inhibiting the progress and well-being of a large proportion of India's peoples.¹⁵¹

According to another historian, P.R. Ghosh, Macaulay represents a critical moment of transition as a direct inheritor of the Enlightenment legacy; as a beneficiary of the further expansive influence of literary Romanticism; and as the great representative English historian of his day, who was committed to 'political science' and 'Whig' history. In this strictly historiographical context, he is a figure of unexpected complexity and uncommon significance.¹⁵² The legal historian C.D. Dharkar has argued that Macaulay

found a people apathetic and inarticulate. He wanted to help them, by giving them better education, better laws formed into a uniform system, and better courts maintaining the spirit of those laws. He wanted to make corruption impossible, to get rid of privilege and to establish in India the principle that all are equal in the eyes of the law. This was an ambitious plan for a single man to achieve during a short term of office. . . . But Macaulay did his best.¹⁵³

An estimate of Macaulay by Surendranath Banerjea

Surendranath Banerjea was the tallest political leader of nineteenth-century Bengal and one of the founders of the Indian National Congress. He was the first Indian leader to face arrest by the British as early as 1883 for defending the sacredness of Hindu idols.¹⁵⁴ He was the first to introduce the ideas of the Italian revolutionary Mazzini as early as early as 1876.¹⁵⁵ He was also the first political leader to advocate passive resistance and boycott and the first to be arrested during the Swadeshi Movement (1905–1909).¹⁵⁶ So Banerjea was an uncompromising champion of Indian culture and Indian freedom.

Surendranath Banerjea was invited on 1 June 1878 to deliver a lecture on the occasion of the thirty-fifth death anniversary of David Hare, a close associate of Rammohan Roy and founder of several schools in Calcutta. Banerjea chose to speak on Macaulay and Indian education:

Zachary Macaulay, the father of Thomas Babington Macaulay had helped to emancipate the Negro slaves, to enfranchise them from physical bondage, to give them that liberty which is the undoubted birthright of every human being. But the bondage which his son was called upon to remove was a far more galling and oppressive in its character. It was the bondage of ancient prejudices, hoary with age and consecrated by time; it was the bondage of immemorial customs, handed down from father to son, through long vistas of rolling years; it was the bondage of intellectual error, the gloom of deep moral darkness.¹⁵⁷

Banerjea stated that Macaulay had rendered a service to Indians even before he landed on the shores of India by framing a section on equal employment opportunity to all Indians in the Charter Act of 1833. The section, 87, clearly stated that ‘no native of India shall by reason only of his religion, place of birth, descent, colour, or any of them be disabled from holding any place, office or employment under the said company.’ Banerjea admitted that ‘we cannot easily forget his unjust strictures upon our national character; but we cannot also forget that Macaulay was the first to uphold equality and the right of every person irrespective of religion, place of birth, descent, colour, or any of them be disabled from holding any place, office or employment. . . . I repeat, then, we should forget the faults and prejudices of the essayist in the recollection of the memorable services he has rendered to the country.’¹⁵⁸

Macaulay’s contributions to Indian education have not been recognised. He was the first to oppose corporal punishment in schools and dismiss a British teacher for beating an Indian boy. He was the first to fix a 30:1 student-teacher ratio. He was the first to talk of secular and inclusive

classrooms and defend the right of the poor and the lower castes for equal access to education. He was also the first to defend the intellectual capabilities of an untouchable boy and provide him with government employment. He was the first to talk of good salaries to teachers and fixed them at ten times more than what the government was willing to pay. And the irony is that Macaulay is the first to be condemned in any writing on Indian education!

Notes

- 1 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, Minutes 3 July 1836, 41, and 25 November 1836, 41–43.
- 2 GCPIC vol. 7, Correspondence between Tytler and H. T. Prinsep.
- 3 Sharp, *Educational Records*, Note by H.T. Prinsep, 15 February 1835, 117–129.
- 4 Report of the Board of Education, 1850, Minute by J. Willoughby, 12 January 1850, 134–192.
- 5 Spear, 'Bentinck and Education,' 70.
- 6 Majumdar, *First Fruits of Education*, 98.
- 7 *Report of the Select Committee on the Affairs of the East India Company*, 1833, 25.
- 8 Hawes, *Poor Relations*, 142.
- 9 Bearce, 'Lord William Bentinck,' 234–246.
- 10 Marshall, *British Society in India*, 90–104. Rosselli, *Lord William Bentinck*, 130, 207.
- 11 Seed, 'Lord William Bentinck,' 67.
- 12 Ehrlich, *The Crisis of Liberal Reform in India*, 2029.
- 13 Speech by Charles Grant on East India Bill, *House of Commons Hansard*, 15 July 1833, Vol. 19, 662. Joseph Hume even opposed giving the East India Company a charter for ruling India for 20 years. He proposed that it should be reduced to 10 years. Ibid, 619.
- 14 Ehrlich, *The Crisis of Liberal Reform in India*, 2030.
- 15 Bentinck's, Minute 1 June 1834, quoted in Frykenberg, 'The Myth of English as a "Colonialist" Imposition upon India,' 313.
- 16 Kopf, *British Orientalism*, 275.
- 17 Prior, Brennan and Haines, 'Bad Language,' 78–79. GCPIC, Vol. 4, Minute by Trevelyan, 13 June 1833. For his opposition to missionary teachers see Minute by Trevelyan, 13 June 1833, GCPIC, Vol 4.
- 18 Fisher, 'Mohan Lal Kashmiri,' 232–242.
- 19 Prior et al., 'Bad Language,' 75.
- 20 Sirkin and Sirkin, 'The Battle of Indian Education,' 419.
- 21 GCPIC, Vol 3, Minute by Trevelyan, N.D. (written between 8 June–6 July 1833).
- 22 GCPIC, Vol. 58, Jenkins to Trevelyan 10 May 1834, Trevelyan to GCPI 10 July 1834.
- 23 Thomas, *The Quarrel of Macaulay and Croker*, 60–64.
- 24 Sullivan, *Macaulay*, 23.
- 25 Macaulay to his father, 23 March 1813, Pinney, *The Letters of Thomas Babington Macaulay Vol. I*, 23.
- 26 As a member of Parliament, Macaulay criticised the supporters of missionaries 'who gives cheap tracts instead of blankets to the starving peasantry,' Pinney, *The Letters*, Vol. II, 156.

- 27 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol. I, Macaulay to his father 10 April 1815, 60.
- 28 Ibid, 187.
- 29 See Macaulay's letters with detailed footnotes in Pinney, *The Letters of Thomas Babington Macaulay Vol I-VI*.
- 30 Schuyler, 'Macaulay and His History,' 164. He called the Lord Chancellor, 'profligate, unprincipled scoundrel,' he was extremely unkind to Scottish kings and people. His sharp tongue invited criticism from one and all.
- 31 Pinney, *The Letters of Thomas Babington Macaulay vol. II*, 147, 189. Others told him that 'you are sacrificed to your family,' Pinney, Ibid, vol. III, 6.
- 32 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, 31 July 1837, 46.
- 33 Ibid, 10 August 1837, 47.
- 34 Ibid.
- 35 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, 30 January 1836, 56.
- 36 Sullivan, *Macaulay*, 109.
- 37 Ibid, 51.
- 38 Thomas, *The Quarrel of Macaulay*, 84–85.
- 39 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol. II, 329.
- 40 Zastoupil, *Rammohan Roy*, 2.
- 41 Thomas, 'The Quarrel of Macaulay,' 213.
- 42 Ibid, 214.
- 43 Finstein, 'A Modern Examination of Macaulay's Case for the Civil Emancipation of the Jews,' 39–59.
- 44 Ibid.
- 45 Ibid.
- 46 Abrahams and Levy, eds., *Essay and Speech on Jewish Disabilities by Lord Macaulay*, 46–52, Speech by Macaulay on Jewish Disabilities Bill, in the House of Commons.
- 47 Pinney, *Macaulay*, Vol II, 103–104, Letter to the Leeds Association, 5 October 1831.
- 48 A Speech by T.B. Macaulay on the East India Bill in the House of Commons on 10 July 1833, 20.
- 49 Cutts, 'The Background of Macaulay's Minute,' 829.
- 50 Masani, *Macaulay*, 124.
- 51 Hall, 'Macaulay's Nation,' 515.
- 52 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol. II, Letter to Nancy, 17 August 1833, 300.
- 53 Ibid, Letter to Hannah, 2 November 1833, 331.
- 54 Sullivan, *Tragedy of Power*, 112, Masani, *Macaulay*, 52.
- 55 Pinney, *The Letters vol. III*, Letter to Margaret, 3 October 1834.
- 56 Masani, *Macaulay*, 123–128.
- 57 Mayhew, *The Education of India*, 17.
- 58 *Board Collections*, No. 77634, Minute by Shakespeare, 18 August 1834.
- 59 GCPI Proceedings, Vol. II, H.T. Prinsep's amendment to Proceedings regarding the Agra College, 11 April 1834.
- 60 *Board Collections*, No. 77634, Minute by H.T. Prinsep, 28 April 1834.
- 61 Ibid, Minute by Prinsep, 15 August 1834.
- 62 Ibid, Minute by Shakespeare, 18 August 1834.
- 63 Ibid, Note by H.T. Prinsep, 9 July 1834, Note by Shakespeare 10 July 1834.
- 64 Ibid, Minute by J.R. Colvin, 14 August 1834.
- 65 *Board Collections*, No. 81568 (no date), December 1834.
- 66 Ibid, Prinsep to Macaulay, 8 December 1834.
- 67 Masani, *Macaulay*, 88.
- 68 *Board Collections*, No. 77634, GCPI Resolution, 21 January 1835.

- 69 Ibid, Sutherland to James Prinsep, 21 January 1835 (Arabic translation of Hooper's Anatomists Vademecum, Hutton's Mathematics Vol I, Crocker's Land Surveying, Hooper's Physician Vademecum, Bridge's Algebra, and Sanskrit translation of Hooper's Anatomists Vademecum).
- 70 Ibid, Sutherland to Prinsep, 22 January 1835.
- 71 GCPIC, Vol. 7, GCPI to William Bentinck, 14 February 1829.
- 72 Ibid, see numerous correspondence between Tytler and H.H. Wilson.
- 73 GCPIC, Vol. 2, Minutes by Trevelyan, 8 June and 13 June 1833.
- 74 Tytler to Macaulay, 26 January 1835, Sirkin and Sirkin, 'The Battle of Indian Education,' 422-423.
- 75 Ibid, Macaulay to Tytler, 28 January 1835.
- 76 Ibid.
- 77 *Board Collections*, No. 77633, Minute by Thomas Babington Macaulay, 2 February 1835. Italics added.
- 78 Ibid, Note by H.T. Prentiss, 15 February 1835.
- 79 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 2 February 1835.
- 80 Ibid, Note by H.T. Prentiss, 15 February 1835.
- 81 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 2 February 1835.
- 82 Ibid, 'Radha Cant Deb assured me that to the best of belief there not, even at Banaras, a single student of the higher Sanskrit learning who is not paid.'
- 83 Day, *Recollections of Duff*, 55.
- 84 *Board Collections*, No. 77633, Minute by Macaulay, 2 February 1835.
- 85 Ibid.
- 86 Ibid.
- 87 Ibid.
- 88 GCPIC, Vol. 58, contains numerous petitions; the one by Brij Mohan Haldar of a school at Bahala village has highest signatures of 704 in Bengali, English, and Urdu.
- 89 *Report of the Indian Education Commission*, 1882, 36.
- 90 Education, 1 January 1870, 1-10 A, 'A Full Report of the Public meeting on Education and Road Cess question, convened by the British Indian Association, 2 September 1868.'
- 91 Minute by Macaulay, 2 February 1835.
- 92 *Board Collections*, No. 77633, Bentinck's Resolution, 7 March 1835, Public letter from India 30 September 1835.
- 93 *Board Collections*, No. 77634, Sutherland to Prinsep, 3 March 1835.
- 94 Ibid, Prinsep to Mahommedan Petitioners, 9 March 1835.
- 95 Ibid, Minute by Macnaghton, 24 March 1835.
- 96 Ibid, Minute by James Prinsep, 30 April 1835.
- 97 Ibid, 20 May 1835.
- 98 Bearce, 'Lord William Bentinck,' 236.
- 99 Legislative despatch to India, 14 April 1836, Despatches to the government of India and Bengal, No. 8., 741-744, quoted in Ballhatchet, 'The Home Government and Bentinck's Educational Policy,' 225-226.
- 100 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol. III, Letter to Calcutta Petitioners, 12 March 1835, 124.
- 101 Liberty of Press Act No. XL of 1835, passed on 3 August 1835, Theobald, *The Legislative Acts*, 7-10.
- 102 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol. III, Macaulay to Bentinck, 27 February 1835, 137.
- 103 Henry Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, 28, 42.
- 104 Ibid, 10 May 1837, 35.
- 105 GCPIC, Vol. 2, Minute by Macaulay, 25 March 1835.

- 106 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, 29 August 1835, and 2 December 1835, 25–28.
- 107 GCPIC, Vol. 19, Samuel Davis, Secretary to Patna School to Sutherland, 13 November 1835.
- 108 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, Minutes, 26 February 1836, 24 March 1837, 2 August 1837, 53–55.
- 109 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 21 June 1836, 18 March 1837, 25 August 1837, 58–61.
- 110 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 28 September 1836, 12.
- 111 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 26 March 1835, 12.
- 112 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 26 February 1835, 18, undated Minute, 29.
- 113 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 15 August 1835, 26.
- 114 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 7 August 1835, 24.
- 115 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 30 January 1837, 36.
- 116 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 28 July 1836, 40.
- 117 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 9 May 1836, 40.
- 118 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 6 October 1835, 16 and 18 November 1835, 27.
- 119 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 4 May 1837, 102.
- 120 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 6 May 1835, 74.
- 121 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 3 June 1835, 75.
- 122 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 21 December 1836, 82.
- 123 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 1 July 1835, 3 November 1835, 23–24.
- 124 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 23 November 1836, 43.
- 125 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 11 February 1836, 54.
- 126 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 28 December 1837, 65.
- 127 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 7 May 1836, 68.
- 128 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 25 November 1836, 66.
- 129 GCPIC Barkley Duncan to the College Committee, 28 September 1836. The list of students comprised 2 Eurasians, 11 Muslims (3 Syed, 5 Sheik, 3 Pathan), 63 Hindus (20 Brahmin, 9 Bengali, 16 Kayasth, 3 Khatri, 9 Bania, 3 Dhusar, 2 Rajput, 1 Sonar), and one native Christian.
- 130 GCPIC, 22 February 1837, Vol. 11, List of Those Considered for Employment.
- 131 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, Minute 31 March 1837, 67. There were three boys by the name Balmokund at Agra College during 1830–1838. Balmokund from Mandarbagh was a Bania, Balmokund from Anupsher was a Brahmin who became a Hindi teacher at Agra College in 1839, and Balmokund from Agra was a native Christian and the author of the essay.
- 132 GCPIC, Vol. 11, On the Advantages of Education, Balmokund, January 1837.
- 133 Ibid, Barkley Duncan to GCPI, 8 March 1837.
- 134 Pinney, *The Letters*, vol III, letter to Bentinck, 7 February 1835.
- 135 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, Minute by Macaulay, 3 July 1836, 41.
- 136 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 8 May 1837, 62.
- 137 GCPIC, Vol. 4, Minute by H. T. Prinsep, 8 July 1836.
- 138 Woodrow, *Macaulay's Minutes on Education*, Minute, 30 August 1836, 44.
- 139 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 30 December 1836, 51.
- 140 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 24 August 1835, 13.
- 141 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 19 October 1835, 80.
- 142 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 2 July 1836, 42.
- 143 Ibid, Minutes by Macaulay, 24 April 1837, and 26 August 1837, 90–102.
- 144 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 28 December 1836, 89.
- 145 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 24 May 1837, 55.

- 146 Ibid, Minute by Macaulay, 28 January 1837, 103.
- 147 GCPIC, Vol. 4, petition accompanying Robert Dowett's letter to H.T. Prinsep, 3 July 1838.
- 148 See *Speeches Delivered at a Public Meeting for the Formation of a British India Society*, London, British India Society, 1839.
- 149 Thomas, *The Quarrel of Macaulay and Croker*, 298.
- 150 Schuyler, 'Macaulay and His History,' 163.
- 151 Frykenberg, 'The Myth of English,' 305.
- 152 Ghosh 'Macaulay and the Heritage of the Enlightenment,' 359.
- 153 Dharkar, ed., *Lord Macaulay's Legislative Minutes*, 167.
- 154 Banerjee, 'The Growth of the Press in Bengal,' 46.
- 155 Fasana, 'Deshabhakt,' 42–44.
- 156 Ray, *Social Conflict and Political Unrest*, 153–154.
- 157 *Speeches and Writings of Surendranath Banerjee*, 92–93.
- 158 Ibid, 94–95.